

Company: Barclays

Job Profile: SDE

Offer Type: Placement Only

Internship Stipend: N/A

CTC: 13.5 LPA

Location: Pune

Resume:  Saurabh_Gupta_Barclays.pdf

Contact: 9518752082

Process Date:

OA round : 26th July 2025

PPT + Interviews : 29th July 2025

Placement Process:

Hello guys,

The entire placement journey was both challenging and tested my perseverance. Before Barclays, I had cleared all the rounds at PhonePe but was unfortunately rejected in the Hiring Manager round. That experience was disheartening, especially because I had dedicated a lot of time and energy preparing for that opportunity — consistently practicing on platforms like Codeforces, CodeChef, LeetCode, Atcoder, and CSES, etc

That setback impacted my confidence and performance in the subsequent companies. However, when Barclays visited our campus, I saw it as a fresh opportunity—and I'm happy to share that I cleared all the rounds successfully.

My key message to all future candidates is: **have faith in yourself and in your efforts.** If you've worked hard, it will pay off sooner or later. Rejections are part of the process, and luck does play a role. What matters most is giving your best every single time, regardless of the outcome.

1. **Online Assessment Round** [135 students appeared for this round and 37 students shortlisted]

The Online Assessment (OA) round was conducted on 26th July 2025 at 11:00 AM in offline mode at the college campus. The test was hosted on the HackerEarth platform. It consisted of a total of 15 questions, and the duration was 90 minutes.

The 15 questions were divided into the following three sections:

Section 1: MCQs (13 Questions)

This section included multiple-choice questions from topics such as OOPs (Java), DBMS (SQL), code

snippet output-based questions, Operating Systems (OS), and Computer Networks (CCN).

The MCQs were largely focused on Java OOPs concepts and were conceptual and slightly tricky. It is important to be well-prepared in core CS fundamentals. In my opinion, the MCQ section was the key shortlisting factor, as most students were able to solve the DSA and SQL questions.

Section 2: SQL Question (1 Question)

This was a basic SQL query-based question involving date and time functions. The task was to find the names of employees who were working only in the month of October.

I solved this using the `WHERE` clause along with the `LIKE` operator.

Although this question was easy, I have encountered much more difficult SQL questions in assessments for other companies such as MSCI. Therefore, it is important to be well-prepared. I highly recommend practicing the SQL 50 questions sheet available on LeetCode, which I had completed prior to this test.

Section 3: DSA Coding Question (1 Question)

Interestingly, this was the exact same question that was asked in the previous year's Barclays placement and summer internship OA. Since I was already aware of it, I was well-prepared.

Question link:

<https://leetcode.com/problems/lexicographically-smallest-generated-string/description/>

Solution Link:

<https://leetcode.com/problems/lexicographically-smallest-generated-string/solutions/7042670/simple-greedy-constructive-approach-c-by-s03n>

My Approach:

I started with the DSA question and completed it first. Then, I moved on to the SQL question. Both were completed in about 15 to 20 minutes. After that, I carefully attempted the MCQ section, as I knew it would be critical for shortlisting.

Preparation Tips:

#Tip 1: Start preparing for core CS fundamentals and OOPs concepts 2 to 3 months in advance. Even though I code in C++, I prepared OOPs in Java specifically for such assessments.

#Tip 2: Practice the SQL 50 sheet on LeetCode thoroughly. Also, review window functions, as they are commonly asked in interviews.

#Tip 3: Begin DSA preparation at least 6 months before placements. I am more inclined toward DSA and competitive programming, so I maintained a daily streak on LeetCode and participated in contests. It's not mandatory to do competitive programming on platforms like Codeforces, but it definitely helps.

You can refer to Striver's SDE Sheet for structured practice. I personally followed Love Babbar's DSA Playlist in C++ during my preparation.

2. Technical Round [37 Students Appeared and 21 Students Shortlisted]

I cleared the OA round, and the interview process was scheduled on 29th July 2025. We were asked to report by 8:30 in the morning. However, since I stay in Kalyan, more precisely in Shahad, and it takes around 1.5 to 2 hours to reach college, unfortunately, I missed my train and reached college a little late. The Barclays Pre-Placement Talk (PPT) had already started, but in a hurry, I submitted one copy of my resume to the TPC and rushed to attend the PPT. Please make sure to come early and be on time. During the PPT, they discussed Barclays' RISES principles. While attending, make sure to note important points like their values, culture, company's Tech Stack, RISES principles, etc.

The first technical interview round began shortly after. I was called to panel number 4. I went there, knocked on the door, and asked for permission to enter. I greeted the interviewer, Mr. Rahul Sir, who was himself an alumnus of SPIT.

He started by asking how my day was and where I stayed. I shared that I commute daily via local trains and the metro, and how I manage my time effectively—solving problems, studying, and listening to music while traveling.

The discussion then moved toward my project section. I have a total of three projects listed on my resume, all of which are Full Stack MERN projects. He began with my third project, **Zerodha**. He asked me to explain the project. Then he asked how I take user info—does it include personal information like bank details? I answered yes, we take such details and perform encryption and hashing to secure them.

He then asked how the data gets stored in the database and which database I used. I explained that I used MongoDB, a NoSQL database, and also justified why I chose MongoDB.

Next, he moved on to my second project, **Job Portal**, which is a job application platform. He asked how job seekers' data and their experiences are stored in the database, how I collect the data, and how it gets reflected on the UI. When the recruiter clicks on the user details, how does the page render the information? What are the schemas for the candidates and recruiters?

I explained all of this on pen and paper. I also demonstrated how I implemented the `.map()` function in JavaScript and React to render user info dynamically. I described how I implemented dynamic search filters in the project.

After this, he came to my first project, **StudyNotion**, an EdTech platform. He asked why I created this project—what was the inspiration? I told him about my mentoring and teaching experience at Wegyan Institute, and how I wanted to build a platform where students could watch lectures if they missed offline classes. I also discussed features like assignments, DPPs, and other functionalities I implemented.

Later, he asked me some basic Java concepts. Although I am primarily a C++ programmer, I had also learned Java. So if you know Java, it will definitely help in the interview.

Make sure you know your resume thoroughly because they can ask anything and everything from it.

At the end of the interview, he said he was done with his questions and asked if I had any questions for him.

It's always a good idea to ask company-relevant questions to show your interest. I asked:

- What roles and responsibilities would I have if selected, and how can I improve in those areas?
- Can you share your role in the company and the department you work in?
- What is the most fun thing you love about working at Barclays?

He answered all these questions very well, and the interview finally concluded.

This round lasted for around 40 to 45 minutes.

3. **Techno + HR Round** [21 Students Appeared for this round]

After the first round, I was a little bit confident that I had given my best in the interview and might be called for Round 2. So, I started preparing for standard HR questions using ChatGPT and also revised some questions I had written down in my notes. Meanwhile, I was called in for the second round.

The second round began, and the interviewer asked me how my first interview was. I replied that it went well and was taken by Mr. Rahul Sir, who is our alumnus, and that he shared how he got into Barclays, etc.

For some candidates, this round was a pure HR round, but for me, it was a mix—I was asked both technical and HR-based questions. The interviewer went through my resume and asked about JWT authentication, which I had mentioned in my project. He asked, "What exactly is JWT?" I explained how it contains three sections: payload, header, and signature. He then asked follow-up questions like what does "expiry" mean in JWT, is it set by default or manually, what is the main purpose of JWT, and whether it is stored on the client side or server side. I answered all these questions properly, and we had a discussion around cookies as well.

Later on, he asked how I learned multiple programming languages.

Then he asked, "Have you ever misunderstood anything? If yes, what action did you take, and what was the conclusion?" This was a good question, so I asked him if I could take a minute to think. He said yes. Then I told him about one incident from a past semester: I had misunderstood the exam schedule. I thought the next day was the OS paper, but it was actually the DAA paper. I had prepared for OS, but just 2 hours before the exam, I got to know it was DAA. However, since DAA was my favorite subject and I had solved thousands of problems related to Data Structures and Algorithms, I quickly revised my notes and gave the exam. I ended up scoring well. He seemed impressed with this response.

After that, he asked what contributions I had made in my group projects and about my hackathon experience. I answered everything in detail.

Then he asked, "Have you done anything in your life whose fruits are still being enjoyed by someone?" Since I had already mentioned that I mentored and taught more than 100+ students in offline batches, I told him that some of my students cracked the NEET examination with good marks. He then asked how I got into teaching just after giving my JEE Advanced exam, and also asked what my percentile was.

After all these questions, he said, "Good to know all these things from you," and then told me he was done with his questions. He asked if I had any questions for him.

I asked, “While working at Barclays, if I want to learn new technologies and frameworks, how can I do that and what is the process?”

This round lasted around 30 to 45 minutes.

Finally, 16 students were selected—and I was one of them.

Useful Tips:

- **Balance DSA & Development:**

Don’t get stuck in the *DSA* vs. *Development* debate. Strive to maintain a healthy balance between both. While DSA and CP build problem-solving skills, in interviews your projects and CS fundamentals often take center stage.

- **Maintain a CGPA of 8+:**

Aim for a CGPA of at least **8.0** to ensure eligibility for most on-campus companies. No matter how skilled you are, missing eligibility criteria due to CGPA can be disheartening.

- **Revise CS Fundamentals:**

Core subjects like **OOPs**, **DBMS**, **OS**, **CN**, and **SQL** are crucial. These are frequently asked in interviews and can make or break your performance.

- **Basic System Design Knowledge:**

Get familiar with basic **system design** concepts. I was asked about this in my **PhonePe HM round**, so don’t ignore it.

- **Master One Language:**

Be fluent in at least one programming language—**C++** in my case, but **Java** or **Python** are equally good. Depth matters more than breadth here.

- **Build Strong Projects:**

Have **at least two solid and unique projects** in your resume that you can explain thoroughly and confidently. Your ability to discuss them can drive the interview forward.

- **Participate in Coding Contests:**

Regular participation in **CP contests** sharpens your thinking under pressure and builds speed—both essential in coding rounds.

- **Stay Consistent and Positive:**

Do your best, be consistent, and give every opportunity your 100%. Remember, **luck also plays a role** on interview day. Don’t get disheartened by rejections—keep going. Opportunities will come; just stay calm, hopeful, and focused.

Resources I Followed:

DSA:

Leetcode (Enough For On-campus Placement)

Competitive Programming (Helps a Lot) → CodeForces, CodeChef, AtCoder, etc

[Strivers A2Z DSA Course/Sheet - Crack Any FAANG or PBCs](#)

[CP-31 Sheet by Priyansh - TLE Eliminators](#)

[CSES Problem Set - Tasks](#)

SQL: [SQL 50 - Study Plan - LeetCode](#)

DBMS: [Complete DBMS in 1 Video \(With Notes\) || For Placement Interviews](#)

OS: [Complete Operating Systems in 1 Shot \(With Notes\) || For Placement Interviews](#)

CCN: <https://whimsical.com/networking-cheatsheet-by-love-babbar-FcLExFDezhhfsbDPfZDBv>

OOPS:

<https://whimsical.com/object-oriented-programming-cheatsheet-by-love-babbar-YbSgLatbWQ4R5paV7EggFw>

[OOP's Concepts in Java - YouTube](#)

Stay consistent, build smart, and believe in your preparation. Placement season can be intense, but with the right mindset and preparation, you'll do great.

Finally I would say, "मेहनत का फल ज़रूर मिलता है। बस धैर्य और निरंतरता बनाए रखें।"

All the best for your placements, Just Give Your Best!

Feel free to reach out: [LinkedIn](#)